

Matthew Shera

GAME DIRECTOR & SYSTEMS DESIGNER

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Game director and systems designer, currently leading design on an IP-licensed party game at Amber Studio, with six years leading design on card and dice games and fifteen competing in them. I lead multidisciplinary teams with AI-assisted workflows, design free-to-play and hybrid economies that reward play, and hold the first fifteen minutes of a game to the highest standard. I lead with experience, respect, empathy and, above all, kindness.

EXPERIENCE

2026-present

Lead Game Designer Amber Studio

Leading game design on an IP-licensed party game for a major media company. Defining the core experience, social and party mechanics, and onboarding for a broad, casual audience while keeping play faithful to the licensed brand. Driving design direction through AI-assisted prototyping and rapid iteration, and collaborating with engineering, art, production and external IP stakeholders to deliver a polished, brand-aligned experience.

Project: IP-licensed party game (NDA) · Party & social design · Core loop · Onboarding · AI-assisted prototyping · Creative direction · Team management

2026-present

Founder & Director Shipless Inc. · Toronto

Designed, built, art-directed and balanced SHIPLESS, a co-op sci-fi survival dice crawler, end to end as sole developer: a seeded deterministic rules engine, a 66-card content set, a free browser client with a between-runs metagame, a print-ready pipeline, and a marketing site. Ran an AI playtest harness of 1,800+ full playthroughs that found and fixed real balance bugs before launch.

Direction · Systems & economy · Engineering · Art direction · Go-to-market

2024-2026

Game Director Anomaly Games

Led studio-wide vision for AI-driven game experiences across multiple live titles. Progressed from Associate Game Director to Game Director, managing cross-functional teams across design, engineering and art. Built MCTS- and CFR-based simulation workflows for economy balancing and player-behaviour modelling. Designed onboarding systems targeting the first 15 minutes of play to maximise retention. Drove creative direction, hiring, go-to-market strategy and live ops.

Games: Pocket Knights (mobile CCG), Don't Die (roguelike auto-battler), Goonville (cozy sim), Gmeow (idle stacker), Moo.F.O. (clicker)

2024

Systems & Economy Designer Clevrer

Designed the next generation of arena-based MMO battlers using AI-assisted balancing and content generation. Shaped hybrid free-to-play and Web3 economies with game designers and an economist, covering core onboarding, progression, monetization and retention.

AI-assisted design · Economy design · Production · Prototyping · Unreal

2024

Systems Designer P1 Games

Collaborated with designers displaced by the 2023–2024 industry layoffs to build Final Melody, an anime RPG inspired by Pokémon, Guitar Hero and music.

Mentorship · Production · Direction · Prototyping · Miro · Unity

2020–2024

Lead Game Designer Horizon Blockchain Games

Led Skyweaver’s game vision while managing a team of seven junior game designers. Co-led the Clash of Inventors and Hexbound Invasion expansions; drove the Hero Ability update, Quests 2.0, Ranked 2.0 and Economy 2.0. Drove AI adoption across the design team and collaborated cross-functionally with engineers and artists. Improved retention 240% and player satisfaction 47%; grew ARPU from \$0.23 to \$2.41. Skyweaver was a 2023 GAM3 Awards nominee for Best Mobile, Card and Strategy Game.

Team management · Economy design · UI/UX · Expansion design · Narrative · Machinations · Figma

2018–present

Freelance Game Designer Self-employed

Consulting on game, systems and economy design for commercial titles across mobile, PC and licensed IP: free-to-play monetization, onboarding, core loops and AI-assisted design pipelines.

Projects: EVE Frontier (CCP Games), Marvel Snap (Second Dinner), Palphabet, Netflix (NDA)

2010–present

Competitive TCG Player & Coach Magic: The Gathering, Yu-Gi-Oh!, Chaotic, Lorcana

Long-time competitor, most recently Top 64 at DLC Toronto, and coach for aspiring players, focused on critical analysis, deck building and a stoic competitive mindset.

EDUCATION

BEng Mechatronics Engineering, Honours

Ontario Tech University · 2015–2018

Red Seal Engineering Leadership Gifted Certificate, Honours

Western Technical-Commercial School · 2011–2015

AWARDS & SPEAKING

GAM3 Awards 2023 — nominee

Best Mobile, Card & Strategy Game, for Skyweaver

Panelist — NextGen Play: AI & Web3 Gaming Summit

“The Future of Game Ownership”

McCall Mechanical Engineering Scholarship

Western Technical-Commercial School · 2015

3× Gracious Professionalism Award

FIRST Robotics · 2012, 2014, 2015

CERTIFICATIONS

Professional Scrum Master

Scrum.org · 2024

Game Writing Certification

ELVTR · 2024

UX Design Specialization

Google · 2023–2024

TOOLS & PROJECTS

AI

Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, Midjourney

Design

Machinations, Figma, Miro, Notion, Jira, Adobe Creative Suite

Engines

Godot, Unity, Unreal

Battalion — CCG board game

Personal project, ongoing: six ancient civilizations, drafted Cores, Attackers, Blockers and Energy units